

Jingcheng Jiang

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ACADEMIC APPOINTMENTS

**2025–
Current** **University of Tokyo**, Tokyo, Japan
JSPS Post-doctoral Fellow
Host Researcher: Yasuyuki Sawada

EDUCATION

2021–2025 **Hitotsubashi University**, Tokyo, Japan
Ph.D. in Economics
Committee: Kensuke Teshima (Chair), Chiaki Moriguchi, Atsushi Yamagishi, Yukichi Mano

2019–2020 **University of Queensland**, Brisbane, Australia
Master of Economics & Public Policy
Advisor: Haishan Yuan

2016–2019 **Massey University**, Auckland, New Zealand
Bachelor of Business Management

RESEARCH FIELDS: APPLIED MICROECONOMICS

Applied Microeconomics, Development Economics, Political Economy, International Trade, Chinese Economy

GRANTS & FELLOWSHIPS

2025– **Grant-in-Aid for JSPS Fellows (KAKENHI)**
Japan Society for the Promotion of Science

HONORS & AWARDS

2026 Hayami Award (速水賞), Japanese Association for Development Economics (開発経済学会大会)

2023 Excellent Paper Award, The 2nd Peking University Summer School in Education

2022 Excellent Paper Award (優秀論文賞), The 17th Applied Econometrics Conference (第17回応用計量経済学コンファレンス)

2020 Distinction, University of Queensland

Politically Induced Internal Trade Barriers in China*Job Market Paper**Revise & Resubmit at Journal of Public Economics*

Competition among subnational governments generates internal trade barriers, fragmenting markets within nominally integrated economies. In China's decentralized system, where provincial authorities evaluate city leaders on relative economic performance, politicians face incentives to maximize locally appropriable gains while minimizing spillovers to rivals. Exploiting exogenous variation in promotion incentives driven by the age of city party secretaries (1996–2018), I show that intensified within-province competition significantly reduces inter-city trade flows, dampens international exports, and restricts firm access to intermediate inputs. Under competitive pressure, politicians reallocate resources toward non-tradable sectors, specifically real estate, while underinvesting in connective infrastructure near jurisdictional borders. I develop a spatial general equilibrium model with endogenous trade costs where politicians choose infrastructure, subsidies, and land provision. Calibrating the model to Chinese provincial data reveals infrastructure accounts for 60% of the competition-trade relationship, and eliminating competition would increase aggregate welfare by 2.8%.

Corruption and the Allocation of Subsidies in China: The Role of Hometown Preference*Revise & Resubmit at Economic Development and Cultural Change*

Can anti-corruption enforcement improve allocative efficiency when political connections distort industrial policy? Exploiting China's 2013 anti-corruption inspections as a plausibly exogenous shock, I show that enforcement reduced subsidies to hometown-connected firms, with effects concentrated entirely on opaquely described allocations while transparent subsidies remained unaffected. This pattern reveals politicians curtailing corrupt rather than legitimate transfers when monitoring intensifies. Reductions operate primarily through behavioral change among continuing leaders as hometown favoritism transforms from career asset to career liability, disrupting clientelistic equilibria. Despite lower subsidies, regional productivity increases as resources reallocate from politically connected to more productive firms, with gains concentrated among smaller enterprises previously crowded out by larger incumbents in politicians' hometowns. These findings demonstrate a pattern consistent with politicians optimizing under enforcement constraints: when detection costs rise, corrupt transfers decline, career incentives reverse, and efficiency improves as misallocated resources flow toward productive firms, illuminating both how political connections generate substantial misallocation and the institutional mechanisms that restore competitive dynamics.

Covid-19, Migrants, and Automation in China (with Yalan Li)*Reject & Resubmit at Labour Economics*

Can policy-induced uncertainty over labor supply permanently redirect the direction of technological change? We answer this question by documenting an unintended consequence of China's zero-COVID policy: by blocking hundreds of millions of migrants from reaching urban manufacturing centers, mobility restrictions triggered a sudden labor supply collapse of nearly 60% in survey data and accelerated automation investment. We find that migrant-dependent counties see post-COVID growth in robotics patents but no change in total patenting, confirming targeted labor-saving innovation rather than a generalized R&D response. The automation response is concentrated in counties with tight labor markets, where missing migrants could not be substituted by local workers, consistent with binding quantity constraints rather than gradual price changes as the operative mechanism. We rule out alternative explanations based on social distancing, export surges, local industrial policy, and demand-side shocks. Migrant workers bear the bulk of the adjustment costs, experiencing persistent income declines and transitions into informal employment. Our findings demonstrate that transient mobility restrictions can generate permanent industrial upgrading by redirecting technological change when labor constraints bind.

Political Tenure, Land Reallocation, and Retreat from Trade

I examine how the tenure of local political leaders affects land markets, fiscal capacity, and economic geography in China. Using a panel dataset linking city politicians to land transactions, fiscal accounts, and trade flows, I document three stylized facts: industrial land is initially priced substantially below residential land by local politicians, but this gap narrows as politicians' tenure lengthens; longer tenure correlates with systematic reallocation of land from industrial to residential use; and central government fiscal transfers decline with political tenure. I develop a multi-region spatial general equilibrium model with trade and costly migration to interpret these findings. When calibrated to match city-level data, the model attributes approximately 30% of observed intercity trade decline and 25% of export contraction to tenure-driven land price convergence and reallocation effects.

Near Rivals, Distant Allies: Ideological Alignment and the Geopolitics of Proximity

Standard gravity models predict that proximity fosters trade, yet international relations theory suggests proximity breeds conflict. This paper formalizes the security externality of international trade to resolve this tension. Using data on trade flows, alliances, and disputes, I document a near-rivalry paradox: proximity lowers transport costs but sharply increases conflict probability, creating a tradeoff between efficiency and security. I show that ideological alignment is the critical mechanism unlocking regional integration. Exploiting exogenous leader turnovers that generate sharp shifts in bilateral ideological distance, I find these shocks disproportionately affect trade between proximate pairs. A network formation model rationalizes these findings: proximity amplifies the security risk of trade, generating a commitment problem, while ideological affinity signals peaceful intent, unlocking high returns from low gravity costs. Calibration reveals ideological distance acts as an 8% tariff between rivals, and counterfactuals show ideological fragmentation would sever the most efficient short-distance trade links.

From Classroom to Harvest: The Effect of International Agricultural Price Shocks on Child Labor in Rural China (with Mengying Peng)

This paper documents heterogeneous effects of agricultural price shocks on child labor and human capital in rural China, driven by crop skill intensity. Using a shift-share design interacting global price fluctuations with baseline local cropping patterns, we classify crops as labor- or skill-intensive via farmer education data. Price increases for labor-intensive crops significantly reduce middle school enrollment and increase child labor, while skill-intensive crop price increases promote higher education. Farm- and individual-level data corroborate these mechanisms via income, land use, and educational spending responses. Our findings show that these price dynamics yield lasting gender disparities in human capital.

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

2019–2020 **Teaching Assistant**, University of Queensland
Introductory Econometrics, Public Economics

INVITED SEMINARS & CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

2026 Japanese Association for Development Economics (JADE); Keio Applied Economics Workshop; GRIPS Economics Workshop (*Scheduled*); The 15th Spring Meeting of The Japan Society of International Economics (*Scheduled*); China Economist Society China Annual Conference (*Scheduled*); Asia Meeting of the Econometric Society, East & Southeast Asia (*Scheduled*)

2025 Econometric Society World Congress; 19th North American Meeting of the Urban Economics Association; ASSA Annual Meeting (AEA); GSE-OSIPP-ISER

Joint Conference in Economics (University of Osaka); Japanese Society for Quantitative Political Science Winter Meeting, Human Capital and Labor Market Research in China Conference

- 2024** Asian and Australasian Society of Labour Economics (AASLE); East Asian Economic Association 19th International Conference (EAEA); Econometric Society East & Southeast Asia Meeting; Association for Education Finance & Policy (AEFP); Japanese Association for Development Economics (JADE)
- 2023** Econometric Society European Winter Meeting (ESEWM); Asian and Australasian Society of Labour Economics (AASLE); East Asian Economic Association 18th International Conference (EAEA); Peking University Summer School in Education
- 2022** The 17th Applied Econometrics Conference

INTERVIEWS & MEDIA COVERAGE

- 2026** [VoxDev](#) — *The Hidden Cost of China's Bureaucratic Promotion System*

PROFESSIONAL AFFILIATIONS

American Economic Association (AEA) · Econometric Society · Japanese Association for Development Economics (JADE) · Japan Society of International Economics

REFeree SERVICE

Journal of Asian Economics x1; Pacific Economic Review x2

SKILLS

Languages Chinese (Native), English (Fluent), Japanese (JLPT N2)

Software Stata, Python, R, MATLAB, ArcGIS/QGIS, LaTeX

REFERENCES

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